

Things You Can Do to Protect the Privacy of Your Data

Almost every day, we hear of data breaches in some website or the other. Since the loss of one's privacy can result in serious consequences, read on to learn how to protect it in a Linux environment, by taking a few simple steps.



Data privacy is an area of concern, due to the ways in which personal information can be misused if it falls into the wrong hands. Privacy can be related to information that personally identifies someone, or other information like the browsing behaviour and the sites visited by people. The logs can be used to gather personal information about individuals.

A few simple methods that can be used in the Linux environment to protect your privacy are given here. They will help to maintain your confidentiality to some extent. All the commands and tools were tested on an Ubuntu 18.04 system.

Use a space before a command

The Linux Bash shell stores the commands typed by the user in the *History* file. The number of commands that are stored can be configured as per the convenience of the user.

Adding a space (“ ”) before the command will prevent the latter from being saved in the *History* file. This could be used to prevent the saving of confidential commands, particularly those that involve giving passwords as part of the command.

\$ command

Notice that the ‘whoami’ command with the space inserted before it is not displayed by the *History* command. The number, 5, after the *History* command is the option given, which indicates the number of the previous commands to be displayed.

In case the above method does not work in your system, then the environmental variable *HISTCONTROL* should be set to *ignorespace* or *ignoreboth*, after which the commands

```

Command Line
File Edit Tabs Help
sn@sn-toshiba:~$ whoami
sn
sn@sn-toshiba:~$ history 5
 7  ls -l
 8  ps
 9  free
10  clear
11  history 5
sn@sn-toshiba:~$

```

Figure 1: Output of the *History* command in response to a command given with a space before it